proposed transhipment port do not affect marine biodiversity in the long term?

We have incorporated a series of regulatory, technical and scientific safeguards for this. For dredging and reclamation, the project is required to follow a detailed dredge management plan. The EC mandates deployment of underwater silt/ sediment containment curtains to prevent dispersion and deposition of suspended material on sandy shores and coral habitats. Dredging in rocky areas is specifically prohibited to avoid ecological and disaster-related risks. Further, dredging and reclamation activities must strictly consider sea turtle nesting and hatching seasons and adhere to internationally recognised protocols prepared by IUCN (International Union for Conservation of Nature) experts and the marine turtle specialist group. Automatic monitoring sensors in port and reclamation areas are to be installed, and dredge management is to be overseen by nationally reputed institutions such as National Institute of Ocean Technology or the National Institute of Oceanography. Periodical shoreline change studies and coastal geomorphology assessments are also mandated, with mitigation measures such as living shoreline techniques to be undertaken wherever required.

Q. What about coral ecosystems and sea turtle protection?

The ZSI has prepared a comprehensive coral conservation and translocation plan. The institute is required to maintain systematic GPS-based monitoring of each translocated coral colony to assess survival and long-term ecological recovery. For sea turtle protection and vessel movement, the EC mandates that movement of ships within Galathea Bay must consider real-time satellite telemetry data generated by the WII. Ecological marker buoys and exclusion zones are to be established to demarcate turtle nesting areas and restrict vessel intrusion. Installation of turtle deflectors on suction equipment is required to prevent accidental intake during dredging.

Institutionally, a monitoring committee on pollution-related matters chaired by the member secretary of the State Pollution Control Board has been established, comprising CPCB (Central Pollution Control Board) representatives and nationally reputed experts in air, water, noise, soil and solid waste management. A separate biodiversity monitoring committee chaired by the principal chief conservator of forests (wildlife) oversees implementation of marine and coastal biodiversity safeguards. These committees are required to meet biannually, undertake site visits and upload proceedings publicly, ensuring transparency and adaptive management.



“The transhipment port at GNI will have locational advantages over competing ports in Bay of Bengal. The dual-use civil-military airport will help our defence preparedness”

Q. Given the scale of forest diversion (including primary tropical forests), can afforestation in mainland India, as is being proposed, truly compensate for biodiversity loss in a unique island ecosystem?

The total forest land proposed for diversion is 130.75 sq. km out of a total project area of 166.10 sq. km. This constitutes approximately 1.82 per cent of the total forest area of the ANI and about 2 per cent of the total geographical area of the Union Territory. Even after the proposed diversion, the remaining forest cover will be well above the two-thirds benchmark prescribed under the National Forest Policy, 1988. The approval under the forest conservation framework has been granted only after examining conservation safeguards for critical ecosystems and allied taxa, ensuring that forest diversion is regulated, phased and legally scrutinised rather than indiscriminate.

The project is structured in three phases extending up to 2047, with only Phase-I activities presently undertaken over 48.65 sq. km of forest land. Tree felling is to be carried out in a phased manner across the project timeline, minimising sudden ecological disturbance. Importantly, 65.99 sq. km of forest area has been earmarked as a green area, where no tree felling is envisaged. The master plan also includes extensive open spaces and designated ‘No-Tree Felling Zones’, reflecting a planning approach that integrates ecological retention within the island itself.

Q. And the compensatory afforestation?

The proposal for compensatory afforestation outside the Union Territory flows from the applicable forest guidelines, which provide that states/ UTs with more than 75 per cent forest cover are not required to identify non-forest land within their territory for CA. Since ANI has more than 75 per cent forest cover, CA is proposed in mainland states having available land banks. Accordingly, approximately 24,750 hectares of land have been identified in Haryana and Madhya Pradesh. The total financial implication towards CA and Net Present Value (NPV) runs into several thousand crores of rupees, and detailed schemes, including 10-year maintenance plans, have been prepared. Site inspections of CA lands have been carried out, and recommendations include soil and moisture conservation works, fencing, water availability and regular monitoring. ■